

Dr Johnson

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If you had walked along Fleet Street 250 years ago, you might have seen a tall man walking alone. He wore old, worn clothes and sometimes made strange movements as he walked. His name was Samuel Johnson. He might have been returning home from Fleet Market, visiting his publisher, delivering an article, or meeting friends in one of the many inns and taverns. Johnson loved London, even though he was sometimes tired of life. His first piece of writing after arriving in London in 1737 was a poem called London. Although it brought him some attention, he spent many years living in poverty before he was given the job of writing his famous dictionary.

The money from the dictionary allowed Johnson to rent a house at 17 Gough Square. He worked there with many books, papers and secretaries. The house still exists and is now open to the public. Johnson later lived in several places near Fleet Street, including Inner Temple Lane and Johnson's Court. He worked as a writer, producing poems, essays, reviews, biographies, translations and other works.

His final home was in Bolt Court, where he wrote The Lives of the English Poets. Johnson died there in December 1784. His body was taken along Fleet Street before he was buried in Westminster Abbey. His life shows how closely he was connected to London and its busy world of writing and publishing.



The attic room in Gough Square where Johnson created his dictionary. His portrait hangs on the wall.



Dr Johnson's house in Gough Square.